Mayawati's undeclared wealth. She offered me Limca and a plate of cashews, and then proceeded to lash out at the media. *'Aap logon ko sharam aani chahiye, kuch bhi dikhate ho!'* (You people should be ashamed, you telecast anything you want.) There wasn't even a hint of apology for the havoc her cadres had caused. Through our meeting, the fearful senior bureaucrats remained standing, none of them even daring to catch her eye.

Mayawati had clearly come a long way from the quiet hostess serving us tea at Kanshi Ram's house. Every day on my way to office in Noida, I would pass the Ambedkar Park, dotted with large statues of Ambedkar, Kanshi Ram and Mayawati herself, and think of Kanshi Ram's furious indictment of the 'statue culture'. A party that had initiated robust Dalit political empowerment was now in danger of becoming a caricature of the very politics it had once despised.

In January 2014, Mayawati's past seemed to catch up with her again. The Supreme Court decided to revive the disproportionate assets case against her. The case filed by the CBI in 2002 investigated Mayawati's vast riches. Her 2012 election affidavit placed her assets at Rs 111 crore and she had many properties in Delhi. Mayawati claimed the money had come in the form of gifts from her supporters. 'That case petrified her,' a Mayawati aide told me. 'She was worried that one day she would go to jail.' There were reports that the BSP leader was negotiating a deal with the Congress in return for protection from the CBI. Some Congressmen claim that it was Rahul Gandhi who nixed any attempt at a BSP–Congress alliance. What was clear, though, was that both sides were desperate—one for political survival, the other for personal immunity from the law. The deal eventually never happened as Mayawati perhaps realized that the Congress was a sinking ship.

During the election campaign, Amit Shah told me that Mayawati had dropped out of the race in the final stretch. *'Iss baar BSP baith gayi hai, chunav ladh hi nahi rahi'* (BSP is not really fighting the elections this time). He was right. In the twenty years of tracking the BSP, I hadn't seen such a listless campaign by the party. No logical explanation has been offered for